The social meaning of constructions: Double modals on British Twitter

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Abstract for the 57th Annual Meeting of the Societas Linguistica Europaea, University of Helsinki, August 2024

Keywords: Construction Grammar; sociolinguistics; cognitive linguistics; corpus linguistics; British English

In this paper, I argue that an explicit incorporation of the notion of social meaning in Construction Grammar (Hoffmann 2022) is a good spur for a *social turn* in this Cognitive Linguistic theory (Geeraerts 2016; Morin et al. 2024). I start by unpacking some key theoretical arguments in favour of this claim **(i)**, and to illustrate them I report a computational sociolinguistic study of double modal constructions on British Twitter **(ii)**.

(i) considers how social information might be delineated in a model of constructional meaning. In particular, what is the precise relationship of social meaning with semantic and pragmatic meaning? I argue that the case of social meaning calls for more fine-grained models of the function of constructions than previously considered (Leclercq 2020). Based on Culpeper (2021) and Morin (2023), I propose a tripartite distinction of pragmatic meaning, with social meaning comprising the meso- and macro-levels of *interactional* and *socio-cultural* meaning. Overall, the integration of social meaning invites us to revisit models of the meaning of constructions, contributing to the 'metatheoretical' stage currently undergone by Construction Grammar research (Ungerer & Hartmann 2023; Cappelle 2024). It improves the explanatory adequacy and predictive power of the theory by highlighting that social meaning is a ubiquitous, though previously underappreciated, source of functional distinction. For instance, it enables us to model synonymy avoidance in language more comprehensively, such as in the form of the *Principle of No Equivalence* (Leclercq & Morin 2023).

(ii) illustrates these points with an in-depth case study of double modals in dialects of British and American English (examples below from naturalistic Tweets; Morin et al. 2024).

• *I **might could** go for some Taco Bell today.* (8 July 2014, Hickman County, Tennessee)

• *i'**ll can** come see ya tomorrow night for a bit if you're no away galavanting* (14 September 2014, South Ayrshire, Scotland)

I argue that double modals are low-frequency, though highly marked, constructions that would elude the purview of Construction Grammar without the modelling of intersectional social meaning. The study relies on a corpus-based analysis of double modals in a large corpus of geolocated Twitter posts. It includes presenting an inventory of observed double modals, the network structure that they exhibit (using eigenvector network graphs and Correspondence Analysis), as well as maps showing, on the one hand, the regional clustering of the forms in the Scottish Borders and, on the other, their low-frequency use across the United Kingdom. These results, combined with qualitative analysis of Tweets, suggest that defining double modals as grammatical constructions requires us to delimit aspects of

their social meaning so as to offset their low frequency or the pre-emptive force of standard alternatives (e.g. *might be able to*), including register and region.

I conclude the paper by arguing that studying regional variation in language use based on large corpora of informal natural language is a promising approach for the future intersection of Construction Grammar and sociolinguistics. Although the study above only relies on a small dialect feature space, I will briefly mention the possibilities of self-supervised Computational Construction Grammar methods (Dunn 2024) to study the social meaning of constructions at scale and across the whole constructicon.

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